SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #106 · SUFFERING

“If I am suffering, God is punishing me.”

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Where it often comes from

Teaching that every hardship is God’s punishment for sin. Friends who asked, “What did you do to deserve this?” A guilty conscience that looks for reasons. Childhood punishment that taught you pain always means you did wrong. Wanting an explanation for suffering.

What Scripture teaches

Sometimes suffering is a natural consequence of sin, and God does lovingly discipline His children for their good. But Scripture does not teach that all suffering is punishment. Job was blameless, yet he suffered greatly, and God rebuked the friends who said it was his fault. Jesus said the man born blind did not suffer because of anyone’s sin. For believers, the punishment for sin fell on Jesus. Suffering is part of living in a broken world, and God is with you in it.

> *“And His disciples asked Him, ‘Rabbi, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he was born blind?’ Jesus answered, ‘Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.’”* **(John 9:2–3)**.

Also see

> “After the LORD had spoken these words to Job, He said to Eliphaz the Temanite, ‘My wrath is kindled against you and your two friends. For you have not spoken about Me accurately, as My servant Job has.’” **(Job 42:7)**.

> “But He was pierced for our transgressions, He was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was upon Him, and by His stripes we are healed” **(Isaiah 53:5)**.

> “Our fathers disciplined us for a short time as they thought best, but God disciplines us for our good, so that we may share in His holiness. No discipline seems enjoyable at the time, but painful. Later on, however, it yields a harvest of righteousness and peace to those who have been trained by it” **(Hebrews 12:10–11)**.

> “For the Lord will not cast us off forever. Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion. For He does not willingly afflict or grieve the sons of men” **(Lamentations 3:31–33)**.

Common self-statements

- God is punishing me for something.
- I must have done something to deserve this.
- This pain proves God is angry with me.
- If I were living right, this wouldn’t happen.
- I have to figure out what sin caused this.
- God wants me to suffer.

Common logical errors

- **Personalization:** Assuming suffering is always about something you did.
- **Jumping to conclusions:** Deciding the cause without evidence.

- **Overgeneralization:** Turning “sin can bring consequences” into “all suffering is punishment.”
- **Projection:** Picturing God as eager to punish.

Challenging questions

- What did Jesus say about the man born blind?
- Was Job suffering because of his sin?
- What did God say to Job’s friends who blamed him?
- Where did the punishment for my sin go, according to Isaiah 53:5?
- Is there a clear sin I need to confess, or am I searching for a reason?
- What does Lamentations 3:33 say about God’s heart?
- Can I trust God’s love even in my suffering?

Truth summary

> My suffering does not automatically mean God is punishing me. Job suffered though he was blameless, and Jesus said the blind man’s condition was not caused by sin. For those in Christ, the punishment for sin fell on Jesus. God may discipline me for my good, but He does not willingly afflict me. He is with me in my suffering.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Suffering
- Troubles
- Guilt/Shame
- Discipline
- Christ, Sacrifice of

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Suffering
- Sin
- Trouble/Hardship

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I am suffering, God is punishing me"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I am suffering, God is punishing me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did Jesus say about the man born blind?
- ☐ Was Job suffering for his sin?
- ☐ What did God say to Job's friends?
- ☐ Where did my punishment go?
- ☐ Am I searching for a reason that isn't there?
- ☐ What is God's heart toward my suffering?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Not all suffering is punishment.
- ☐ Jesus took the punishment for my sin.
- ☐ God does not willingly afflict me.
- ☐ God's discipline is for my good, not my destruction.
- ☐ God is with me in my suffering.
- ☐ Blameless people suffer too.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **John 9:2–3**
  "And His disciples asked Him, 'Rabbi, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he was born blind?' Jesus answered, 'Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.'"

- [ ] **Job 42:7**
  "After the LORD had spoken these words to Job, He said to Eliphaz the Temanite, 'My wrath is kindled against you and your two friends. For you have not spoken about Me accurately, as My servant Job has.'"

- [ ] **Isaiah 53:5**
  "But He was pierced for our transgressions, He was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was upon Him, and by His stripes we are healed."

- [ ] **Hebrews 12:10–11**
  "Our fathers disciplined us for a short time as they thought best, but God disciplines us for our good, so that we may share in His holiness. No discipline seems enjoyable at the time, but painful. Later on, however, it yields a harvest of righteousness and peace to those who have been trained by it."

- [ ] **Lamentations 3:31–33**
  "For the Lord will not cast us off forever. Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion. For He does not willingly afflict or grieve the sons of men."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Suffering journal:** Each day, write one hard thing and one way God showed care or presence in it.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Lamentations 3:31–33 becomes: "For the Lord will not cast **Sarah** off forever. Even if He causes grief, He will show compassion according to His abundant loving devotion. For He does not willingly afflict or grieve **her**."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Suffering" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Read Job 1–2 and 42,** and write what the friends got wrong about Job's suffering.
- ☐ **If there is a clear sin, confess it once,** then stop searching for hidden reasons.
- ☐ **Read John 9:1–7,** and write how Jesus responded to suffering.
- ☐ **Talk with a pastor or Christian counselor** about your suffering and your fears.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I am suffering, God is punishing me": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One sign of God's care in suffering
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I am suffering, God is punishing me.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I am suffering, and I don't understand why. Help me reject the lie that You are punishing me. Thank You that Jesus took my punishment and that You do not willingly afflict me. Be near to me in this hard time and show me Your compassion. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.